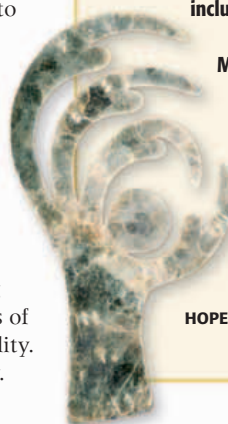




One possible reason these sites were built may have been to ensure the beneficial presence of ancestors at the heart of village life and to allow the living to maintain a connection with the spiritual world (see pp.32–33). Those who performed the rituals that took place here were thought to be able to communicate with the dead and would have been important members of the community.

These structures not only reflect developed beliefs, they also indicate an awareness of the natural world; some, such as Stonehenge, may have been built to mark the summer and winter solstices—critical events in farming societies. They are also striking feats of engineering and organizational ability. Many remain spiritual places today.



HOPEWELL CLAW

The megalithic structures in Europe are echoed around the world in later cultures. They can be seen at sites in many countries, including the US and Japan.

MOUNDBUILDER SITES

Elaborate funerary cults grew in North America after 1000 BCE. By 400 BCE the Hopewell people of the Ohio Valley traded objects like this as part of a cult, in which the dead were interred in mounds.

MISSISSIPPIAN CULTURE

This culture flourished in North America between 1000 and 1450 CE **212–13 >>**. Public ceremonies marked the solstices, and the first harvest was celebrated in plazas surrounded by temples on top of earthen mounds.

FUNERARY CUSTOMS

Elsewhere around the world, funerary customs also played an important role in society. Japan's **Kofun** culture of the 3rd century CE and later is remarkable for its **keyhole-shaped burial mounds**. On the



KOFUN BURIAL SITE

AFTER >>

other side of the world, an Anglo-Saxon King, who has been identified as **Raedwald**, was buried beneath a huge **mound at Sutton Hoo** in Suffolk, Britain, in his richly adorned ship, in 620 CE.

UPHOLDING TRADITION

The tradition of building elaborate sacred sites is

still common today in cultures around the world in the form of Christian cathedrals, Islamic mosques, Buddhist temples, and even in the monuments erected to commemorate American presidents.